HILCHOT SHABBAT

Filtering, Pouring & Straining

Given Thursday 7 May 2026 · Hilchot Shabbat, Siman 319 — מלאכת בורר, זורה, מרקד

Topic: מלאכת בורר — Selecting and Sorting (completing the siman) **Siman:** (319) שיט **Seifim covered tonight:** Seif 6, Seif 7 (Zoreh), Seif 9-16 (Meraked and related) **Source text:** Shulchan Aruch with Rema, Mishna Berura, and Bi'ur Halacha

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Recap: What We've Covered in Borer So Far

The Three Conditions for Permitted Selection

1. **Le'altar / Samuch L'Seudah** — for immediate use
2. **B'yad** — using the hand (or extension of hand)
3. **Ochel from Pesoleth** — taking the wanted from the unwanted

Major Principles Established

- **Two edible foods** — the unwanted is treated as pesoleth (Rama)
- **Borer = selecting AND sorting**
- **Definition of a mixture (ta'arovet)** — required for borer to apply
- **Yom Tov vs. Shabbat** — on Yom Tov, take the easier path (less tircha); on Shabbat, always take the ochel from the pesoleth

Last Three Shiurim's Major Chiddushim

- **Le'altar in seconds (derech achila)** — machloket Maharit Abulafia vs. Maharitatz; halacha not relied upon as sole heter
- **Ein Borer B'Lach** — no borer when a solid is mixed with a liquid (Sefardi and many Ashkenazi poskim)
- **Take the entire small mixture** (fly + spoonful of soup) — universally permitted
- **Guf Echad** — when something is naturally one composition (bones in fish, seeds in watermelon, peel on cucumber, stem on tomato), removing the unwanted is **tikun ochel**, not borer
- **No psik reisha with borer** — a natural action whose inevitable consequence happens to involve separation is permitted (salt shaker with rice, removing a tea bag)

Tonight's Roadmap

We're moving beyond borer proper into the related selecting melachot:

1. **Seif 6** — extracting beans from inedible pods (technically Dash, brought here for context)
2. **Seif 7** — Zoreh (winnowing): the rules of using wind/air for separation

3. **Seif 9-10** — Meraked (sieving/straining): liquids and the three categories of clarity
4. **Seif 11-13** — additional rules around cloths, baskets, and improvised strainers
5. **Seif 14** — pouring out unwanted liquid from a mixture (very practical)
6. **Seif 15-16** — the egg through mustard, drinking water with worms, and churning butter

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Brief Introduction — The Sequence of Selecting Melachot in the Mishkan

Understanding Zoreh and Meraked requires seeing where they sit in the workflow that produced the Mishkan dyes:

Step	Melacha	Action
5	**Dash** (threshing)	Extracting seeds from pods
6	**Zoreh** (winnowing)	Throwing the mixture in the air → wind blows the chaff away
7	**Borer** (selecting)	Hand-selecting good seeds from remaining pebbles/debris
8	**Tochen** (grinding)	Crushing the seeds into powder
9	**Meraked** (sieving)	Sieving the powder to separate fine from coarse

Then the powder was made into paste and used as dye for the Mishkan's roof. **All four selecting melachot (Dash, Zoreh, Borer, Meraked)** appear in this sequence.

Seif 6 — Extracting Beans from Pods (Technically Dash)

This seif is really about **Dash** (the 5th melacha — extracting from an encasement), but the Shulchan Aruch brings it here because it's said in the same Gemara as Seif 7.

What is Dash?

Taking edible food from an inedible encasement — for example, taking grain or beans from their inedible pods.

Important Limitation

- **Edible pods (e.g., sugar snap peas, mangetout):** No issue of Dash, because the whole thing is edible. There's no "encasement" of inedible material.
- **Inedible pods only:** Dash applies — taking out the edible seeds from the inedible pod.

The Three Levels of Action

Method	Status
Opening the pod normally and extracting seeds	**Forbidden d'Oraita**
Rubbing pods between hands to release seeds	**Forbidden mi'derabbanan**
Pressing with the **tips of the fingers** in **small quantity**	**Permitted (with shinui)**

The Halacha (Shulchan Aruch)

אין מוללין מלילות... אלא מולל בשינוי בראשי אצבעותיו

You may extract with the tips of the fingertips, but **only a small quantity** — so it shouldn't appear like weekday activity.

Read carefully: the small quantity is on top of the shinui, not the heter. The shinui itself permits it; the small quantity ensures it doesn't look like a weekday work.

Rema — The Stringent Position

וטוב להחמיר... ולכן אסור לפרק אגוזים בלוזים או אגוזים גדולים מתוך קליפתן הירוקה

The Rambam and Rif understood the underlying Gemara (Beitzah) as applying to **both Shabbat and Yom Tov**. Other Rishonim understood it as applying **only to Yom Tov**. The Rema is machmir like the second view.

Practical:

- **Sefardim:** May press with fingertips in small quantity (following Shulchan Aruch)
- **Ashkenazim:** Should be stringent and not extract from green/inedible shells at all

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PART 2 — Zoreh (Winnowing)

What is Zoreh?

The melacha of Zoreh is **using wind, an artificial air current, or even one's breath to separate impurities from a mixture.**

Examples

- Throwing a mixture in the air so the wind separates chaff from seeds
- Using a fan to blow away lighter particles
- **Blowing on something** to separate (e.g., blowing shells off peanuts) — this can be d'Oraita

Critical Differences from Borer

	Borer	Zoreh
Heter of samuch l'seudah	Yes (with all 3 conditions)	**NO**
Why no leniency?	—	It's a "sophisticated" melacha — using wind has no everyday eating-related dispensation

Therefore: Even immediately before eating, you cannot blow shells off peanuts. That would potentially be **issur d'Oraita**.

Why Wind Counts as a Direct Act (Not Grama)

Generally in halacha, wind is considered indirect (grama). So why isn't every Zoreh a grama (which would be permitted on Shabbat)?

Answer: This is the **derech of the melacha**. The original melacha was performed with wind. Therefore, wind is the direct act here, not the indirect cause.

Zoreh Requires a Mixture

Just like borer, Zoreh only applies when there is a **ta'arovet**. If there's no mixture, there's no Zoreh.

The Peculiar Rema at the End of the Siman

הרוקק ברוח בשבת והרוח מפזר הרוק חייב משום זורה

If a person spits on Shabbat and the wind disperses the spit, the Rema (quoting the Yerushalmi) says he is **chayav for Zoreh**.

Difficulty

Spit appears to be one substance, not a mixture. So how does Zoreh apply?

Resolutions

- Some Acharonim suggest: spit is actually a combination of liquid + phlegm + other elements, so there *is* a mixture being separated by the wind
- **Most Acharonim reject the Rema's ruling here** as not l'halacha
- **The Ben Ish Chai is one notable exception** who does accept it
- **L'halacha:** Zoreh only applies to genuine mixtures

Practical Outflow — Aerosols and Sprays on Shabbat

Based on these principles:

- **It's one substance** (no mixture)
- **Many hold Zoreh applies only to gidulei karka** (things that grow from the ground)
- The combination of these reasons → **deodorants, hairsprays, and other aerosols are permitted on Shabbat**

Seif 7 — Practical Halachot of Zoreh

Setup

You already extracted seeds from pods before Shabbat (no Dash issue), but the seeds are mixed with chaff.

What's Forbidden

לא ינפה בכנון ותמחוי

Method	Status
Use a sieve or utensil	**Forbidden (borer with kli)**
Throw up and down with **two hands**	**Forbidden**
Throw from one hand to the other	**Should be avoided** (Rambam in Peirush HaMishnayot, Mishna Berura, poskim)
Blowing on it	**Forbidden d'Oraita (Zoreh)**

What's Permitted

אלא מנפה בידה אחת בכל כחה

You may forcefully throw up and down with **one hand** only.

Practical Application — Peanuts in Shells

You have a bunch of shelled peanuts mixed with empty shells:

- ❌ Don't throw with two hands
- ❌ Don't toss between hands
- ❌ Don't blow on them
- ✅ Take a handful in one hand, toss it forcefully up and down. Whatever shells fall away, fine. Repeat with one hand if needed.

The principle: **avoid using wind/air currents** as the primary mechanism of separation.

PART 3 — Meraked (Sieving / Straining)

What is Meraked?

The word **meraked** comes from "to dance" — referring to the bouncing/shaking motion of items in a sieve. The classical Meraked is **shaking items in a sieve** so the fine passes through and the coarse remains.

What About a Strainer (Meshamerret)?

The Mishna says a wine strainer (meshamerret) has the same prohibition. But **why?** Two views in the Rishonim:

Position	Rationale
Rashi	A strainer is a type of sieve → forbidden as **Meraked**
Rambam	A strainer doesn't shake items together; it pours one through the other → forbidden as **Borer** with a kli

Either way, **using a strainer on Shabbat in certain circumstances is forbidden d'Oraita.**

Seif 9 — The Major Chiddush: Pouring Water Through Existing Sediments

משמרת אפילו תלויה מערב שבת אסור ליתן בה שמרים

You cannot put fresh wine with sediment through a pre-set-up strainer.

BUT — The Chiddush

אבל אם נתן בה שמרים מערב שבת מותר ליתן עליהם מים

If sediments were already in the strainer from before Shabbat, you **may pour fresh water through them** — even though:

- The water mixes with the sediments
- Then strains out, picking up the wine flavor
- The strainer performs a separation

Why Is This Permitted?

The principle: borer is judged by the moment of action, not the consequences.

At the moment you poured the water in:

- The water itself was clear — no mixture
- Only after pouring does it mix with the sediments and then get strained

Since **at the moment of your action there was no mixture**, no borer occurs. The strainer's subsequent activity is not your action.

Practical Application — Tea Leaves

You used the tea leaves before Shabbat. Used tea leaves sit in the teapot. On Shabbat:

- ✅ Pour fresh hot water in to extract additional flavor
- ✅ Pour out the resulting tea
- The water enters as clear water (no mixture); it leaves having picked up flavor through the tea leaves

This is **muttar** because at the time of pouring, there was no mixture being separated.

Seif 10 — The Three Categories of Liquid Clarity

This is the foundational structure for liquid filtration on Shabbat. Two introductory points first:

Introduction 1 — Three Categories

Category	Description	Status
1 — Achurim Legamrei	Completely cloudy/impure; the vast majority would not drink without filtering	**D'Oraita** to filter
2 — Achurim Ketzat	Slightly cloudy; drinkable, but most prefer to filter	**D'Rabbanan** to filter (with strainer); permitted with cloth
3 — Tzilulim	Basically clear; just want extra refinement	**Permitted** to filter

Introduction 2 — Melaben (Laundering)

The melacha of Melaben (washing/laundering) is relevant here. There's a debate among Rishonim whether soaking a clean cloth is also Melaben (laundering by additional cleansing). Bear this in mind for the cloth rules.

The Halacha (Shulchan Aruch)

יין או מים שהם צלולים מותר לסננם במשמרת אף על פי שיש בהם קסמים דקים

Category 3 (Clear liquid): May use a strainer (meshamerret) even if there are tiny twigs or impurities, since it's already drinkable.

אבל בסודרים אסור משום ליבון

Cloth filter on clear water: Forbidden because of **Melaben** (laundering the cloth) — or alternatively because of **gezeirah shema yischot** (you might come to squeeze the cloth).

ויין ושאר משקין מותר

Wine or other (non-water) liquids in a cloth: Permitted, because there's no Melaben concern (laundering only applies to water).

ואם הם עכורים בין מים בין יין אסור לסננם

Category 1 (Completely impure): Forbidden d'Oraita to filter, whether water or wine.

The Middle Category (Achurim Ketzat) — Implied

The Shulchan Aruch leaves out Category 2 explicitly, but it follows from the framework:

- ❌ Strainer: forbidden (would be borer with a kli at d'rabbanan level)
- ✅ Cloth: permitted (two derabbanans don't combine to forbid)

The Three Categories — Comprehensive Summary

Category	Strainer	Cloth
Category 1 (achurim legamrei)	❌ D'Oraita	❌
Category 2 (achurim ketzat)	❌ D'Rabbanan	✅
Category 3 (tzilulim)	✅	❌ Water (Melaben), ✅ Wine/other

The Rambam's Stricter View

The Rambam was machmir on all three:

- **Strainer** — never permitted, even for clear liquids (weekday activity)
- **Cloth** — only permitted for fully clear, never for any cloudiness
- **Exception** — fresh wine still fermenting (the sediment is part of how it's drunk)

Halacha: All poskim — both Sefardi and Ashkenazi — follow the **first opinion (Shulchan Aruch)**, not the Rambam here.

Practical Applications of the Three Categories

Filter Jugs (Brita and Similar)

Setting	Category	Permitted?
England (drinkable tap water, filtering for refinement)	Category 3	✅ Permitted
Israel (when most don't drink straight from tap)	Category 2	❌ Forbidden
Personal preference only (you alone don't drink tap; family does)	Discussion (batla da'ato)	Be machmir

Tap Strainers

- Pre-installed before Shabbat (no boneh issue)
- Same logic: water type determines the category
- In England (Category 3) → permitted to use

Orange Juice

- **Lots of pulp/pips, undrinkable for most** → Category 1 → strainer forbidden d'Oraita
- **Some pulp, drinkable but most prefer clear** → Category 2 → strainer forbidden d'rabbanan; cloth permitted
- **Basically clear, just refining** → Category 3 → strainer permitted

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Seif 11 — Cloth Strainer Without an Indentation

כשמסננין יין בסודר צריך להזהר שלא יעשה גומא לקבל בו משום שינוי

When using a cloth as a permitted strainer (per Seif 10), **don't form an indentation** in the cloth that would catch the liquid. Keep it flat.

Why? This would be the typical weekday way of using a cloth-strainer. Maintaining shinui keeps it within the heter.

Seif 12 — The Egyptian Basket (Kefifa Mitzrit)

כל מקום שמותר לסנן יין בסודר מותר לסננו בכפיפה מצרית

A kefifa mitzrit (Egyptian-style basket) follows the same rules as a cloth — wherever cloth is permitted, the basket is too.

ויש ליזהר בכפיפה שלא יגביהה משפת הכלי טפח

Caveat: Don't lift the basket more than a tefach (~handsbreadth) above the receiving vessel. Two reasons given:

- Shinui (it should look different from weekday)
- Possible **Ohel** (forming a roof-like covering)

Seif 13 — Don't Build a Strainer at the Mouth of a Vessel

כלי שמערים בו יין מהחבית לא יתן בפיו קשים וקסמים בחזקה שהם מסננים כעין משמרת

If using a vessel to draw wine from a barrel, **do not firmly pack twigs or material at the mouth** of the vessel that would create an improvised strainer. That counts as making/using a strainer.

Seif 14 — Pouring Out Unwanted Liquid (HUGELY PRACTICAL)

מותר לערות בנחת מכלי לחבירו

You may **gently pour from one vessel to another**, even if there's sediment at the bottom.

ובלבד שיזהר כשיפסק הקילוח ומתחילים לראות ניצוצות קטנות הנוטפות באחרונה מתוך הפסולת יפסיק

BUT — when the steady stream stops and only **small drops** start coming out from among the sediment, **stop pouring** and leave those final drops with the sediment. If you continue, the drops being separated from the sediment is **borer**.

Two Critical Principles Here

Principle 1 — A Liquid Mixture Is Local, Not Whole

We've seen this before with the fly in soup. The liquid is only considered "mixed" with the sediment **at the bottom where the sediment is**, not throughout the entire vessel. So pouring off the top — which has no sediment touching it — is not selecting from a mixture.

Principle 2 — The Thing Being Poured Out Is Considered "Taken"

This is the key chiddush. When you pour out something, **what's being poured is what's being "taken"** — even though physically it leaves your hand.

The Chayei Adam disagreed and held the opposite (what stays in your hand is "taken"). But all other poskim follow the main view: poured = taken.

Practical Implications

Tuna Can Oil

- ✅ Pouring off the **top layer of oil** in a steady stream → no problem (you're "taking" the oil; it wasn't mixed at that level)
- ❌ Once it slows to drops mixing with the tuna → **stop**. Continued pouring is borer.
- **If you don't want the oil at all:** Pour off what comes off in a steady stream; for the rest, use a fork to remove the tuna and discard the remaining oil another way.

Peaches in Syrup

- **If you want to drink the syrup:** ✅ permitted (poured = taken; you're taking what you want)
- **If you don't want the syrup, only the peaches:** ❌ Problem. The syrup and peaches are fully mixed throughout. Pouring off the syrup is taking the unwanted from the wanted (borer pesoleth from ochel). **Solution:** Take peaches out with a fork.

Seif 15 — Egg Through Mustard

מסננת שנתן בה חרדל לסננו מותר ליתן בה ביצה אף על פי שהחלמון יורד למטה עם החרדל והחלבון נשאר למעלה

A strainer with mustard already in it from before Shabbat. You may put a raw egg through it:

- The **yolk passes through** and colors the mustard yellow
- The **albumin (white) stays in the strainer**

This appears to be a textbook borer with a kli. **Why is it permitted?**

Two Approaches in the Acharonim

Approach 1 — An Egg Is One Unit

Yolk and albumin together = one substance. There's no mixture, hence no borer.

- **Implication:** You could even separate yolk from white when you actually want the yolk (like for cooking) — permitted any time

Approach 2 — Two Distinct Substances, But No Borer Anyway

- A **cooked** egg is universally one unit (everyone agrees)
- A **raw** egg has more separation between yolk and white, so it might be considered two substances
- Then why is it permitted? Because of the **Pri Megadim's** position: borer is select-and-take. Here you want **neither** the yolk nor the albumin (you only want to color the mustard). Since you're not selecting either as "the wanted," it's just sorting, not selecting.

Practical Difference Between the Approaches

- **Approach 1:** Can always separate yolk/white, regardless of intent
- **Approach 2:** Only permitted in this specific case where neither is "wanted"; if you wanted the yolk for itself, it would be borer

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Seif 16 — Drinking Water with Worms Through a Cloth

מים שיש בהם תולעים מותר לשתותם על ידי מפה בשבת

If your water has insects/worms in it (Category 1 — undrinkable as is), you may drink it through a cloth placed over your mouth.

Why Is This Permitted?

דלא שייך בורר ומשמר אלא במתקן העניין קודם אכילה ושתייה אבל אם בשעת שתייה מעכב הפסולת שלא יכנס לתוך פיו אין זה מלאכה

Borer/Meraked applies only to preparation before eating/drinking. When the act of drinking itself separates the worms (the cloth holds them back as you drink), this is **derech achila/shtiyah** — the way of consuming, not preparation.

This is parallel to (but stronger than) what we learned about taking bones out in your mouth. As a universally accepted derech achila — not a discussion like the salmon-second-before-eating case from last week — drinking through a cloth is fully permitted.

Seif (end) — Churning Butter (Mechavetz)

המחבץ תולדת בורר הוא

Churning butter from milk (Mechavetz) is a **toledah of borer** (Rambam). Therefore:

אף על פי שנותנים שומשמין ואגוזים לדבש לא יחבצם בידו

Even though sesame seeds and nuts are added to honey, **don't churn them with your hand on Shabbat.**

Comprehensive Summary of the Whole Siman 319

Borer (Seifim 1-5, 8) — Already Covered

- Three conditions: l'altar, b'yad, ochel from pesoleth
- Guf echad permits removing bones, seeds, peels from natural compositions
- Ein borer b'lach (Sefardi position)
- No psik reisha with borer
- Take the entire small mixture (fly + spoonful)

Dash (Seif 6) — Tonight

- Inedible pods: pressing with fingertips in small quantity = permitted with shinui (Sefardi)
- Rema is machmir for green nut shells

Zoreh (Seif 7) — Tonight

- No samuch l'seudah dispensation
- Forbidden: blowing, two-handed throwing, hand-to-hand
- Permitted: forceful one-handed up-and-down throw
- Aerosols permitted (one substance + gidulei karka considerations)

Meraked (Seifim 9-16) — Tonight

- **Three categories of clarity:** d'Oraita / d'Rabbanan / permitted
- **Seif 9 chiddush:** judging borer by moment of action (clear water poured through existing sediments)
- **Seif 10:** Strainers and cloths by category
- **Seif 14 chiddush:** the thing poured out is "taken"; stop when stream becomes drops
- **Seif 15:** Egg through mustard (machloket why)
- **Seif 16:** Cloth over the mouth while drinking (derech shtiyah)
- **End:** Mechavetz (churning) is a toledah of borer

Coming Up Next

- **Next week** is our final shiur before Shavuot. Either:

1. **Begin Siman 320** — Hilchot Dash (threshing) and related selecting/processing melachot, or
2. **Shavuot-related shiur**

Decision next week.

Shabbat Shalom

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/yqwB6HLuXp0 · More shiurim: rabbikada.com